The Future Care Conversation Checklist

What to ask, write down and come back to while your wife is well.

Your wife is well, and the subject of future care has never come up between you. This list is for raising it as a conversation about her life, with nothing to decide at the end of it. Check what you've done, in whatever order it happens. Anything unchecked is a conversation that hasn't happened yet, and says nothing about her or about you.

Ask

- [ ] Her permission to talk about the future at all. If she says “not today,” that's her answer for now.
- [ ] What a good day looks like for her, starting with ordinary life: her mornings, her routines, the people and places in her week.
- [ ] What matters most to her, and what she'd most want to keep if things change someday.
- [ ] Each of the kids, and anyone else who would be involved: what they hope for, and what concerns them.
- [ ] Each of them, and yourself: what you could realistically offer, how often, and what you couldn't.

Write down

- [ ] The routines and choices she wants to keep, in her own words where you have them.
- [ ] What she wasn't sure about, or didn't want to talk about yet.
- [ ] Her wishes in one place and the family's hopes in another, so one isn't mistaken for the other.
- [ ] Where two people expect different things. Write both, and leave both on the page.
- [ ] What each person said they could offer, and what it depends on: a job, the distance, their own health.

Come back to

- [ ] What you wrote about her wishes, read back to her, so she can say whether you got it right.
- [ ] The questions nobody in the family could answer, kept on a list for her doctor or another professional.
- [ ] How you'll look at this again as life changes: a date, an occasion, or simply “when one of us asks.”

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you ask, write down and come back. It doesn't say what her answers mean, whether anything should change, or what the family ought to decide. Nothing on it adds up to a score.

Ready for the next step?

You've asked, written down what was said, and marked what to come back to. The care interview adds the rest of your wife's situation, area by area, so her wishes sit beside a full account of how she lives now, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›